



FROM VOICE TO ACTION: WHAT NIGERIA'S YOUNG CLIMATE-HEALTH LEADERS TAUGHT US

In Abuja, young people came together to talk about Climate and Health. What happened next revealed a bigger question: what does it really take to turn youth voices into action? There is no shortage of conversations about Africa's climate future. Additionally, there is no shortage of young Africans ready to shape it. But somewhere between the two, lies a persistent gap: young people may be invited into the conversation without being given the resources, connections or decision-making pathways needed to turn their ideas into action.

This gap was at the center of the Amplifying Youth Voices for Climate-Health Action Youth Pre-Conference, a precursor to the Future of Health Conference convened in Abuja, Nigeria by Nigeria Health Watch. Its premise was simple but significant: if young people are among those experiencing the consequences of climate change and its impact on health, they should not simply be recipients of climate-health policies but should help shape them.

A seat at the table

The youth pre-conference brought together young leaders, policymakers and experts in a hybrid space designed to do more than exchange speeches. There were interactive panels, fireside conversations, breakout sessions and exhibitions. Participants discussed climate-health challenges, exchanged experiences and explored what meaningful action could look like at both policy and community levels. The most important was when the microphone was passed to young people. Participants contributed to evidence-informed policy and operational recommendations and helped develop the **Green Print Manifesto**, a youth informed communique, capturing their priorities and calls for action. Digital platforms extended the conversations beyond the room, while social media helped amplify young people's perspectives to a much wider audience. Strikingly, the conversation did not end when the conference did. A youth advocacy platform, **Youths4Action**, was established to provide a space for continued collaboration, knowledge exchange and advocacy.



Future of health Youth Pre-Conference



Youth Engaging In Discussions On The Future Of Health In Nigeria

What Made the Conference Stand Out

The Amplifying Youth Voices for Climate-Health Action Pre-Conference successfully reached 357 participants, across physical and virtual rooms while digital engagement generated more than 40,000 impressions and 6,000+ interactions. More than 100 young people subsequently joined the growing **Youths4Action** platform. Participants reported increased knowledge, inspiration, and interest on collaboration. Perhaps the most significant outcome was that, young people did not simply need another platform to speak; they needed somewhere for their ideas to go.



Participants During A Plenary Discussion

What Didn't Go as Planned

Despite the energy and enthusiasm, creating conditions that allow the youth's voices to influence systems is relatively difficult. Participants highlighted persistent barriers to funding and institutional support for youth-led ideas. Many young innovators had ideas but lacked clear pathways to mentorship, financing, implementation, and scaling. Furthermore, there was a familiar disconnect between policy dialogue and implementation. A young person can participate in a panel, contribute to a communicate and generate innovative solutions. But who funds the idea? Who mentors the team? Who opens the door to policymakers? Who helps take a promising pilot beyond its first community? These questions became some of the most important lessons from the experience.



Participants During An Interactive Session

Lessons for Governments and Development Partners

1. Build platforms, not just programmes. Youth platforms must be institutionalised rather than treated as one-off events. Networks like Youths4Action should be embedded into governance structures to ensure continuity and accountability, allowing young people to keep learning, collaborating, organising, and advocating after the event banners come down.
2. Put pathways behind the conversations. Dialogues must be paired with tangible pathways such as funding, mentorship, and incubation programs to help youth ideas evolve into scalable solutions. A successful youth engagement model therefore needs to ask not only: "Did we hear young people's ideas?" but also: "What happened to those ideas afterwards?"
3. Climate-health communication should be localised, simplified, and framed in ways that connect with people's everyday realities, communities to drive behaviour change.
4. Governments must support implementation by creating mechanisms for youth innovations to be piloted, tested, and integrated into national strategies, while sustaining engagement through feedback loops that ensure youth contributions are visibly acted upon.

The experience in Abuja showed that young people are ready to help shape climate-health solutions. The next step is ensuring they have the opportunities, support, and partnerships needed to turn their ideas into lasting action that builds more climate-resilient and healthier communities across Africa.



Participants Capturing A Memorable Moment At The Conference Photo Wall

Case Study: Amplifying Youth Voices for Climate-Health Action Shared as part of the CAPCHA case study collection by Chris Bassey, Nigeria Health Watch.

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